

CLAWHAMMER BANJO FOR THE COMPLETE IGNORAMUS!

~40TH ANNIVERSARY EDITION~

BY
WAYNE ERBSEN



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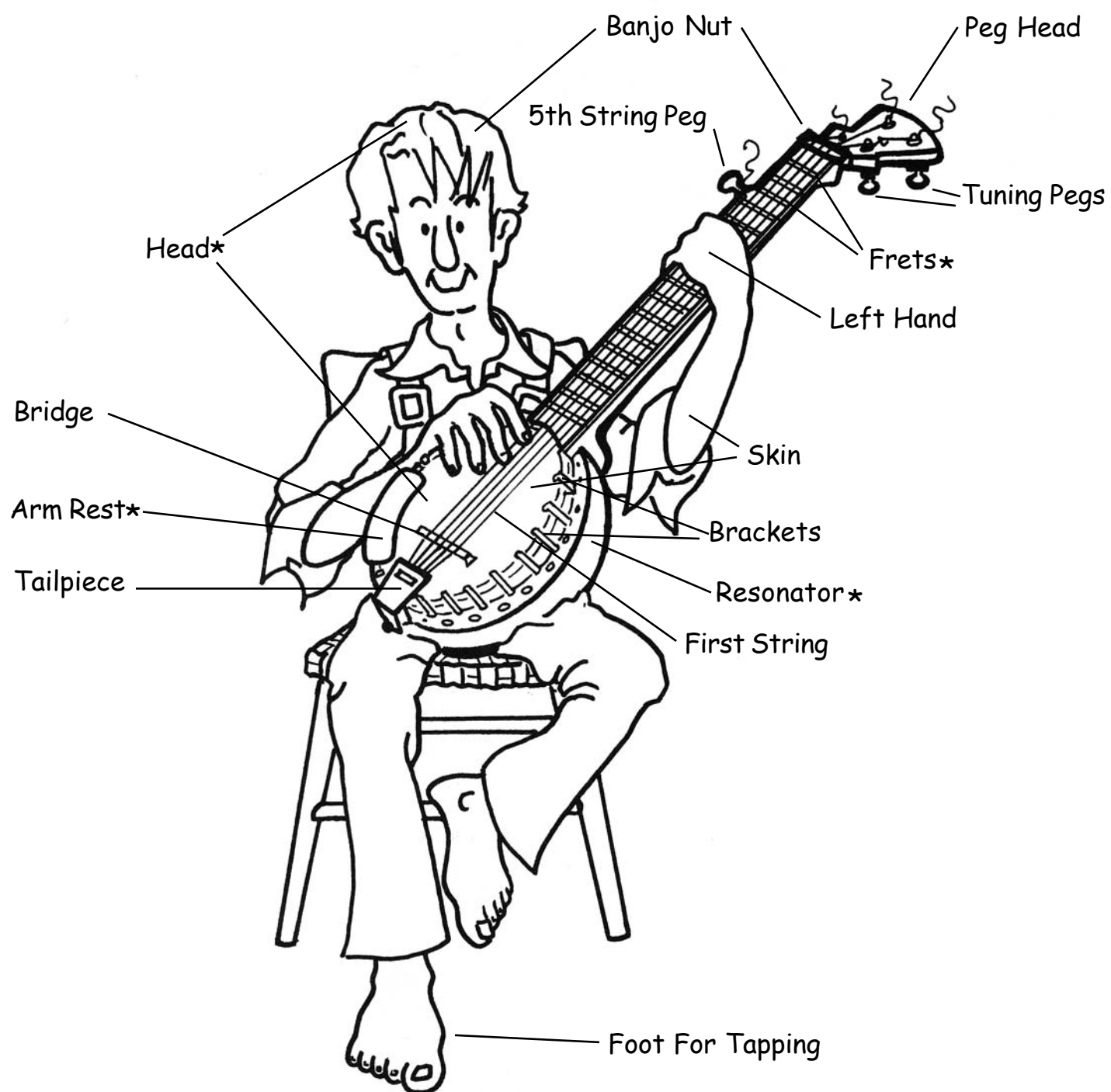
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PARTS OF A BANJO(IST)



Legend: ★= optional

THE RHYTHM OF CLAWHAMMER

Clawhammer banjo picking is a very rhythmic style, so to properly play it you must first get the sound of the rhythm in your ears. The rhythm you are trying to get sounds like the word “clawhammer,” especially when you exaggerate the three syllables: CLAW-HAM-MER. Say it aloud several times.

Start out by tapping your foot in a steady manner. When your foot hits the floor and comes up, say “CLAW.” And the next time it goes down and up, say “HAMMER.” Say that over and over as you tap your foot. When your foot gets tired, switch feet. When they’re both tired, lay down and take a nap! You’ve earned a good rest.



Claw



Ham-mer



Claw



Ham-mer

If you prefer to see the rhythm in musical notation instead of “foot language,” here it is:

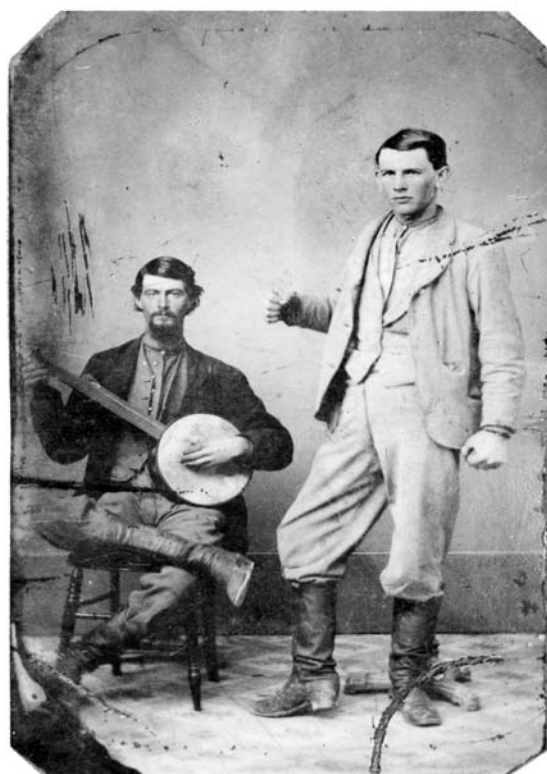


Claw Ham-mer



Claw Ham-mer

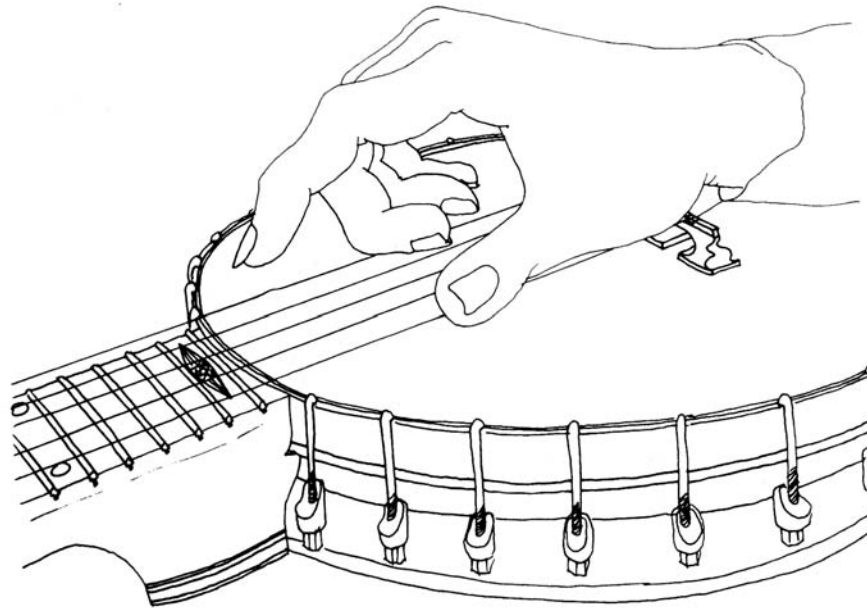
Getting this rhythm is essential to playing clawhammer style.





THE RIGHT HAND

Your right hand, or “claw,” will be your main tool in playing clawhammer banjo. Begin by clenching up your hand, as in the following illustration. Be sure to keep your fingers fairly rigid at first.



First, we're going to learn to play melody notes. You will be using the middle finger of your right hand to play the 1st string and your index finger to play the 2nd, 3rd and 4th strings. Begin by poising your right hand above the strings, as in the illustration above. Using your wrist as a hinge, raise up your hand away from the head slightly, and hit DOWN on the 1st string with the nail of your middle finger. As you are striking the 1st string, your right thumb should firmly come to rest on the 5th string, but don't sound the 5th string yet. The secret here is to make sure to land firmly on the 5th string with your thumb. Try hitting the 1st string over and over, concentrating on getting the thumb to land on the 5th string. Note that on both of the illustrations on this page, the index finger is sticking out, to get it out of the way when the middle finger is striking the 1st string.

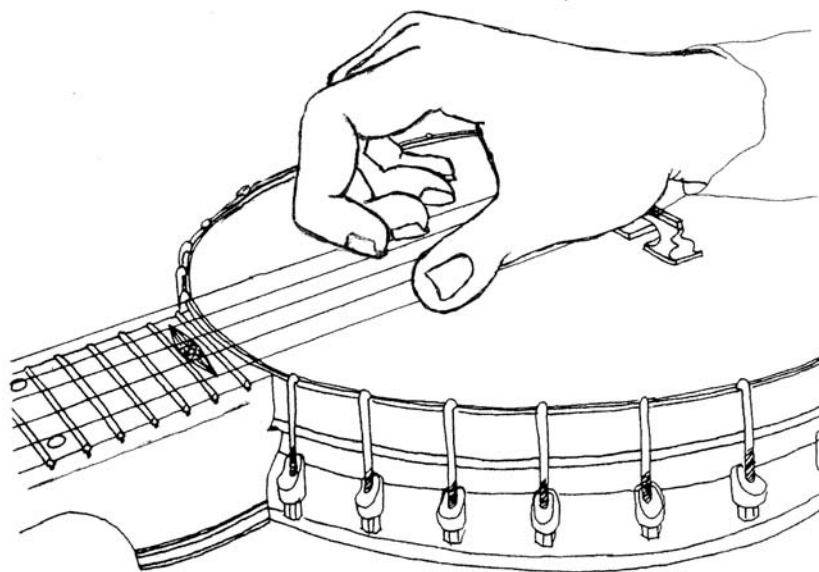


William Sydney Mount

The Banjo Player, 1856

I can tell you are skeptical about the importance of landing on the 5th string with your thumb when you're not even playing it yet. In clawhammer style, you're basically playing in the air, with no point of reference. Making firm contact with your thumb on the 5th string helps you orient your hand, so it knows where it is in space. Imagine you're walking along a hallway in total darkness. Naturally, you'd want to occasionally touch the wall so you'll know where you are. The 5th string is that wall.

Next, you'll use your index finger to play the 2nd string. Pull in your index finger so it's lined up with the other fingers, as in the illustration below. You'll need to lift your right hand at the wrist away from the head, as you did above. As you hit the 2nd string, make sure your thumb lands firmly on the 5th string. Next, practice striking the 3rd and then the 4th strings with your index finger in the same way you did the 2nd string. Remember, each time you strike a melody string, your thumb lands on the 5th string. Take some time and hone down your skills playing these different melody strings (1, 2, 3 and 4) while your thumb comes to rest on the 5th string.



There are basically three parts to the clawhammer “lick,” as we call it down here in North Carolina. Each part will correspond to the rhythm of the word “claw-ham-mer.” The “Claw” will be your melody note, which will be played on the 1st, 2nd, 3rd, or 4th strings. On the “Ham,” you will brush down on the 1st, 2nd, and 3rd strings with your middle and ring fingers. The “Mer” is when you finally hit the 5th string with your thumb.

1) The “Claw.” Lift up your right hand and strike down on the 1st string with your middle finger. Of course, at the same time, your thumb will come to rest on the 5th string.

2) The “Ham.” Just as we did on the “Claw,” raise your right hand at the wrist and strike down on the 1st, 2nd, and 3rd strings with your middle and ring fingers. Again, your thumb will come to rest on the 5th string.



3) The “Mer.” At long last it's time to actually play the 5th string. Lay your thumb flat along the 5th string with the side of your thumb touching the head. As you raise your hand, crook up your thumb joint and hit the 5th string as you are moving away from it. Your goal should be to really crook or bend that thumb joint each time you hit the 5th string.

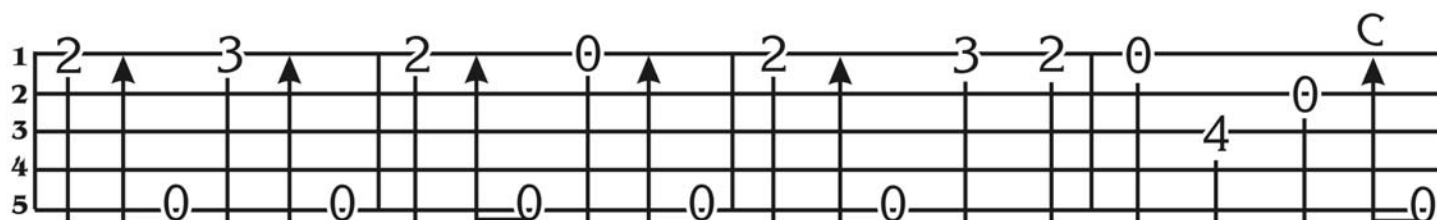
As you practice the three parts of the clawhammer lick, be sure to accent the “Ham” part of your rhythm. It should be claw-HAM-er, claw-HAM-er. This accent is what gives clawhammer style its good rhythmic bounce.

HOW TO READ BANJO TABLATURE

Banjo players seldom use standard musical notation to learn tunes. Instead, they either learn by “ear,” by watching and listening to other people, or by a system that is called tablature, or “tab” for short.



Reading tablature will soon become your second language. It's really easy to read. Here's an example of what a typical song in the *Ignoramus* looks like. In this case, we'll use the chorus of "Old Molly Hare." Normally, each song will have the lyrics under each line of tablature. For this example, however, I've put the words "clawhammer" or "claw" so you can see how the rhythm of the clawhammer fits the tablature.



Clawhammer, clawhammer, clawhammer, clawhammer, clawhammer, claw, claw, claw, claw, clawhammer.

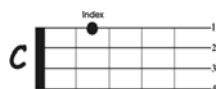
You can see in the example above that the five horizontal lines represent the five strings of your banjo. The numbers on the lines (strings) tell you what fret to play on that string. For example, the first note you see on the left is a “2” on the 1st string. That means you’ll push down, fret, or “mash” (as we say in the South) the 1st string at the 2nd fret with the tip of your left index finger. Remember, you’re supposed to fret the string in the space BETWEEN the frets, not on the fret itself.

You'll notice the first "2" in the example above is followed by an arrow and then the 5th string played open. That's your clawhammer unit. The "2" is the "Claw," the arrow is the "Ham," and the 5th string is the "Mer." Not far from the end of the line you'll see a "3" and a "2." There's no clawhammer lick here. Instead, you just play those individual notes, or "claws." If you turn to "Old Molly Hare" on page 22, you'll see repeat signs at the beginning and end of each line that look like two eyes staring at two fence posts. That just means when you get to the repeat sign at the end of the line, you go back to the first repeat sign and play it again.

For this 40th anniversary edition, I've added measure lines to the tab. Each measure gets four beats, or four foot taps. That's the equivalent of two "clawhammers."

WARNING: Reading tab can become addicting!
Learn to play the tune, not the tab.





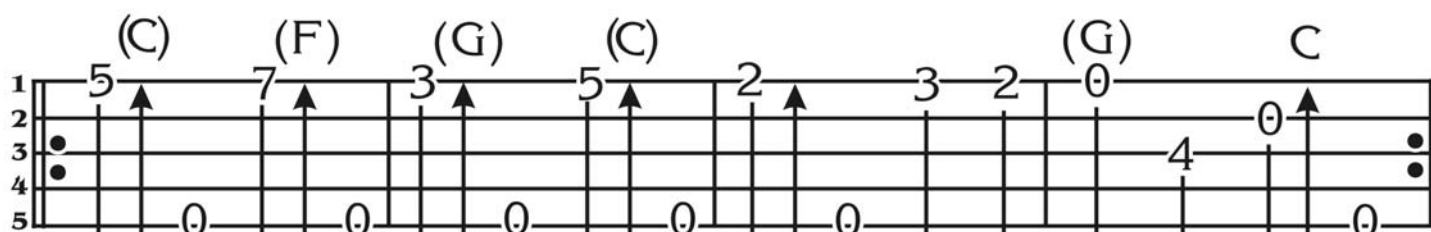
OLD MOLLY HARE

Double C Tuning
gCGCD

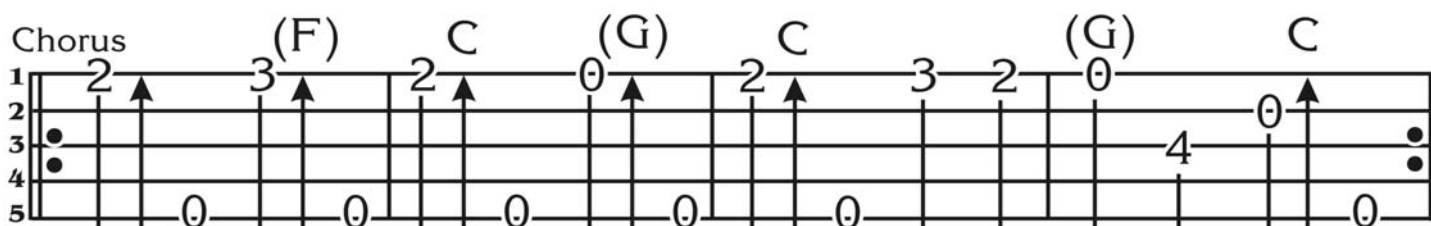
Here is your first tune to play in double C tuning, “Old Molly Hare.” I’ve heard an African song which strongly resembles this tune, so it may well go back even further than to ante-bellum days of the old South. The reason we start with “Old Molly Hare” is that it is a well-known tune where the melody is mostly played on the 1st string, which makes it easier to play. Use your left index finger to play the 1st string at the 5th fret and your left ring finger to play the 1st string at the 7th fret. The best finger to use on the “4” on the chorus is your ring finger. Ignore the chords in parenthesis. They’re for the guitar player.



I collected the first several verses at fiddlers’ conventions in Southwest Virginia and North Carolina in the early 1970s. The verses starting with “Old Granny Hare” were collected from W.E. Bird of Cullowhee, NC on October 28, 1925, by Robert Gordon.



“Old Molly Hare what you doin’ there?” Sittin’ by the fireplace smokin’ my cigar.



Jump back, jump back, daddy shot a bear, shot him in the eye and he never touched a hair.

Old Molly Hare what you doin’ there?
Runnin’ through the cotton patch as fast as I can tear.

Old Molly Hare what you doin’ there?
Sittin’ in the butter dish pickin’ out a hair.

I’d rather be here than to be over there
A whole mess of cockleburs tangled in my hair.

Old Granny Hare what you doin’ there?
Runnin’ through the cotton patch as hard as I can tear.

Wheat bread, cornbread or any such a thing
The old sow died with the measles in the spring.

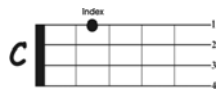
Old Granny Hare what you doin’ there?
Sittin’ in the corner smokin’ a cigar.

The old sow’s leg or the old sow’s tail
Make as good a hammer as ever drove a nail.

You can ignore the chords in parentheses. The only chord you’ll need to play is the “C” at the end of both lines. The melody is the 2nd string “open” or unfretted, but you’ll need to hold down the “C” chord for the “Ham” of the clawhammer.



After you can play “Old Molly Hare,” you can add some pull-offs. See page 56.



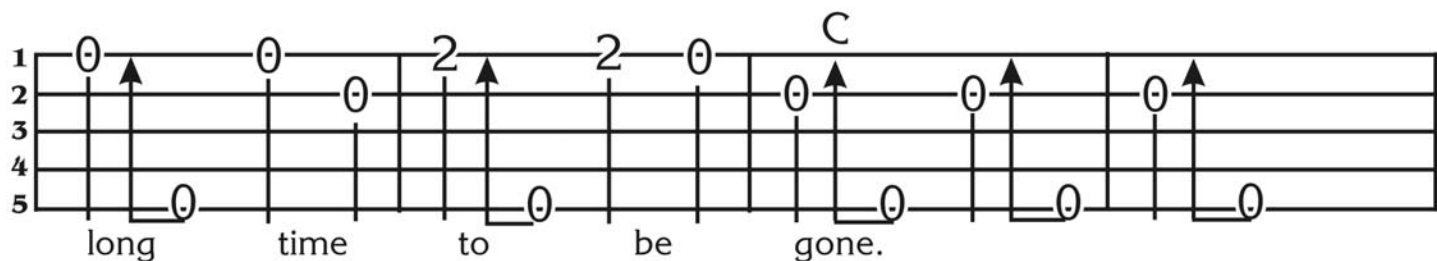
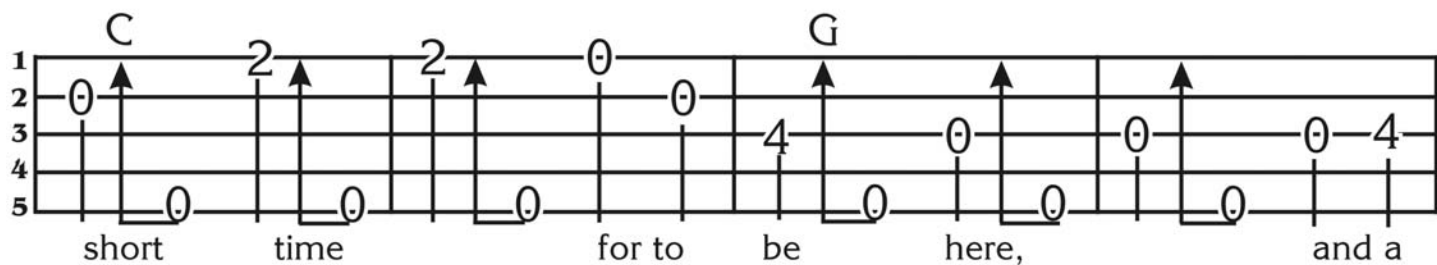
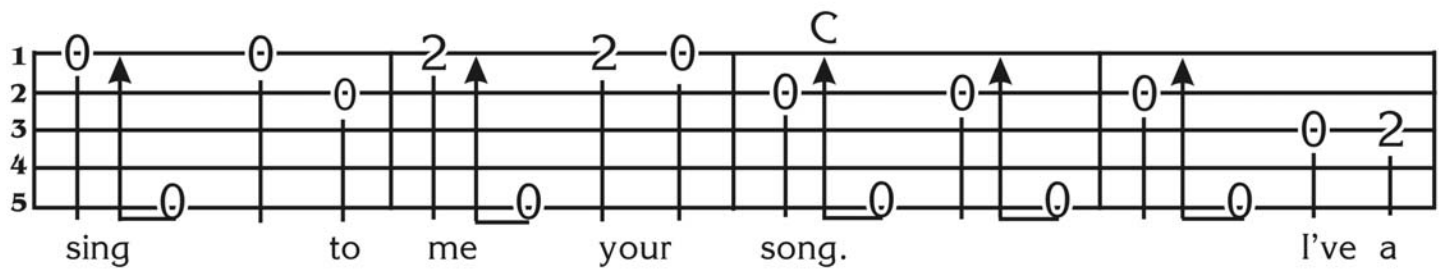
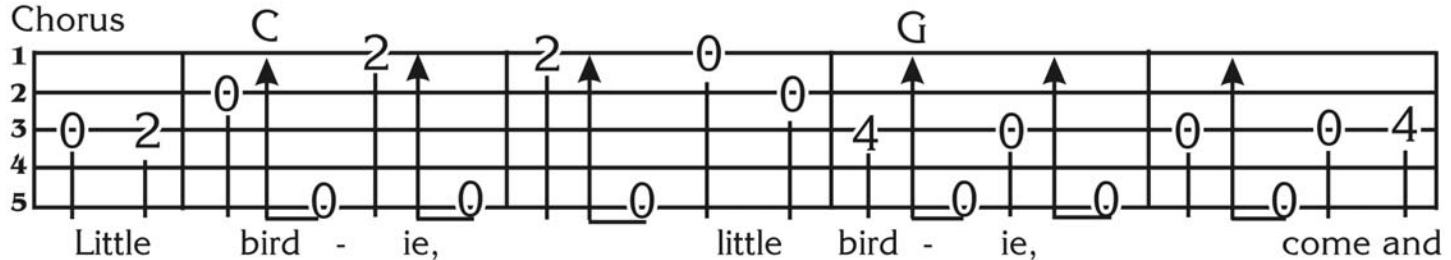
LITTLE BIRDIE

Double C Tuning gCGCD

This well-known song has been used by Ralph Stanley for the past sixty-plus years as a showpiece to highlight his old-time clawhammer skills. Remember to hold down a C chord starting at the first measure of the song. On line one I suggest you make a simple G chord by fretting the 2nd string at the 2nd fret using your index finger. At the same time you're playing the G chord, you'll also need to play the melody note (the 3rd string at the 4th fret). Be sure that both of your fingers land on the strings at the same time. By the way, always stay on a chord until a new chord is called for.



Chorus

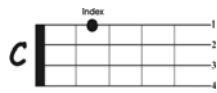


I'd rather be in some dark holler
Where the sun don't ever shine.
Than to see you with another
And to know that you'd never be mine.

Married woman, married woman
Why don't you settle down?
You are like a little birdie
A-flyin' all around.

Little birdie, little birdie
Why do you fly so high?
'Cuz I mourn for my true lover
Away up in the sky.





LYNCHBURG TOWN

Double C Tuning
gCGCD

I originally learned this song from a recording by a group named The Louisiana Honeydrippers, who called it “Who’s Going Down to Town.” I later found out the song is more commonly called “Lynchburg Town,” and it goes back to pre-Civil War days. A number of the verses are known as “floaters,” as they float from song to song.

You need to play a “C” chord at the beginning and the end of the song, but the other chords are optional on the banjo. At the beginning of line two, you’ll want to play the “3” with your left index finger and the “7” with your pinky. Likewise, use your pinky to play the “5” over the word “carry” on line two and your middle finger to play the “4” at the end of the word “tobacco.”



After you can play “Lynchburg Town” as written, try adding a hammer-on to the very first “2,” at the beginning of line one. (See page 56.) This will give the song some punch from the git-go.

Chorus C

Who's goin' down to town who's goin' down to town

Who's goin' down to Lynchburg town to carry my tobacco 'round.

Once I had an old blind dog
I wished they'd bring him back.
He run them big hogs over the fence
And the little ones through the cracks.

I married me a little gal
And I brought her from the South.
She balled her hair so doggone tight
She couldn't shut her mouth.

Possum up a 'simmon tree
Raccoon on the ground.
Raccoon said, "You son of a gun,
Shake them 'simmons down."

Possom shake the tree
'Simmons start to fall.
Raccoon said, "You doggone fool,
I didn't want 'em all!"

Johnson had an old grey horse
His name was Martin Brown.
Every foot old Martin had
Would cover an acre of ground.



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Photo by Wanda Levin

Barbara Swell & Wayne Erbsen, 1986

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